Social Influence Effect on Aesthetic Judgments

Omar Lizardo & Sara Skiles

June 2026

Abstract

In this research note, we address the question, foundational to sociological studies of taste, of the extent to which others' aesthetic judgments influence the transient evaluation of cultural works, and the extent to which this influence depends on the social distance between self and other. Drawing on classic and recent cultural theory, we hypothesize that high (low) status respondents (as indexed by educational attainment) will be more likely to change their judgment of a cultural object in a negative direction when exposed to information about the negative aggregate judgment of other persons of high (low) status in comparison to when those judgments come from others of low (high) status. We use a quasi-experimental design to manipulate both exposure to others' evaluations and the status characteristics of those others.

1 Introduction

1.1 Theoretical Background

Taste expressions and consumption have long been shown to be a function of individuals' desire to differentiate themselves from others (Simmel, 1957; DiMaggio, 1987). Bourdieu (1984) suggests that taste differences evoke a visceral reaction, and it is through the rejection of others' aesthetic tastes that individuals engage in the symbolic boundary work that separates them. Thus, the expression of distastes is a means of communicating social distance from certain social groups (Bryson, 1996; Lamont and Molnár, 2002). In contexts where individuals discover a similarity in taste with members of a meaningful outgroup, they frequently engage in "taste abandonment" to maintain social boundaries (Berger and Heath, 2008). Despite the robust literature on the relationship between cultural familiarity and network connections (Erickson, 1996; Lizardo, 2006), relatively little is known about the dynamic mechanisms underlying symbolic boundary work in real time.

How does access to the evaluations of others influence our own aesthetic evaluations of cultural objects? Traditional models in the sociology of culture and consumption use a balance-like logic, suggesting that access to positive evaluations from others will increase subjective evaluations of worth when those others are positively regarded, but not when they are negatively regarded. In the same way, access to other people's negative evaluations will lead to a decrease in subjective evaluations of worth when those others are positively regarded.

To understand these dynamics, we must first consider *generalized influence mechanisms*. The basic idea behind generalized influence is simple: in any context where there is some level of uncertainty about how to evaluate a cultural object, access to information regarding how others have evaluated it provides a heuristic that helps resolve that uncertainty. As such, individuals tend to adjust their own evaluation in a direction consistent with the valence of other people's evaluations. For instance, discovering that a cultural object is broadly endorsed by others often increases its appeal (Positive Generalized Alignment), while discovering it is disliked decreases its appeal (Negative Generalized Alignment).

However, cultural influence is rarely so monolithic; the status of the "others" matters. Exposure to the preferences of a high-status group might induce *conformity* (alignment), whereas exposure to a low-status or out-group might induce *reactance* (distancing). We specifically explore how the respondent's objective and subjective class status interact with the fictional group's class status to produce theoretically distinct behaviors: staying, conforming, or reacting.

1.2 Hypotheses

Baseline Condition (Mere Exposure Effect):
Overall we expect that mere exposure to the same cultural object over repeated trials results in an average improvement in evaluation, even in the absence of information on how other persons evaluate the object. Access to information regarding other people's evaluations serves to block or facilitate this mere exposure effect.

Evaluation Only Condition:

- **Positive Evaluations:** Positive evaluations (liking) from generalized others should have an overall positive influence on the respondent's second evaluation, facilitating the baseline drift.
- **Negative Evaluations:** Negative evaluations (disliking) from generalized others should have an overall negative influence on the respondent's second evaluation, blocking the mere exposure effect.

Status Plus Evaluation Conditions (Cross-Status Reactance and Symbolic Power):

- **Hypothesis 1 (Same-status association):** High (low) status respondents will be more likely to change their judgments in a negative direction when exposed to the aggregate negative judgment of others of high (low) status.
- **Hypothesis 2 (Symbolic power):** Low status respondents will be more likely to change their judgments in a negative direction when exposed to the aggregate negative judgment of others of high status.
- **Hypothesis 3 (Cross-status reactance):** High (low) status respondents will be more likely to change their judgments in a positive direction (distancing) when exposed to the negative aesthetic judgment of others of low (high) status.

2 Data and Methods

2.1 Experimental Design and Data

We utilize data from the SSI-2012 survey. The core of the study is a within-subject experimental design where respondents rate an artwork on a 7-point scale ("taste1"), are exposed to a treatment condition, and then rate the artwork again ("taste2").

The treatment conditions vary along three dimensions regarding a fictional alter group:

1. **Taste Evaluation:** Whether the alter group *liked* or *disliked* the artwork.
2. **Status of the Alter:** High-status (College educated/Middle class) versus Low-status (Working class/No college).
3. **Control/Taste Only:** Conditions where only the alter's taste is known, but no class information is provided, as well as a pure baseline control.

2.2 Variables

- **Dependent Variable:** The primary outcome is the shift in aesthetic evaluation. We analyze this as a continuous change score, an ordinal structure using Cumulative Link Mixed Models (CLMM), and a nominal behavioral outcome (Stay, Conform, React).
- **Independent Variables:** The experimental condition factors.
- **Moderators:** Respondent status consistency, captured by Working/Middle Class crossed with College/No College.

2.3 Analytic Strategy

Our data consists of repeated measures (before and after providing access to others' evaluations) of the respondent's aesthetic evaluation of a cultural object. Because repeated measures are correlated within subjects (but independent across subjects), we rely on random-effects models as a natural framework to simultaneously model within and between subjects variance. We use hierarchically nested versions of the mixed-effects model via maximum likelihood and use likelihood ratio tests to select the best fit.

To overcome the limitations of standard linear regression and fully test our hypotheses regarding alignment vs. distancing, we additionally employ three advanced modeling techniques:

1. **Cumulative Link Mixed Models (CLMM):** To respect the bounded, ordinal 1-7 scale of the dependent variable.

2. **Multinomial Logistic Regression:** To disaggregate shifts into Conformity and Reactance based on the direction of the alter's feedback.

3. **Propensity Score Weighting (IPW):** To balance demographic covariates (age, gender, race, parent's education) across observational status groups, ensuring the moderating effects of class are not confounded.

3 Results

3.1 Linear Baseline and Trial Effects

First, we replicate the original nested linear mixed models. The model including the interaction between the experimental condition and the trial period provides the best fit, confirming that social influence varies significantly depending on the status of the fictional group.

3.2 Trial Effects by Status Consistency

The effect of social influence is highly moderated by the respondent's own class and educational background. As shown in Figure 1, the shifts vary across condition and status groups.

3.3 Cumulative Link Mixed Models (CLMM)

Because taste is a 7-point Likert-type scale, treating it as a continuous outcome can result in biased standard errors and out-of-bounds predictions. We implemented a Cumulative Link Mixed Model (CLMM) to respect the bounded ordinal nature of the data.

The CLMM results validate the original linear approach but provide unbiased effect estimates. By respecting scale boundaries, the CLMM ensures that respondents who already rated the painting a "7" in Trial 1 are modeled correctly (they cannot shift higher), preventing boundary-induced underestimation of treatment effects.

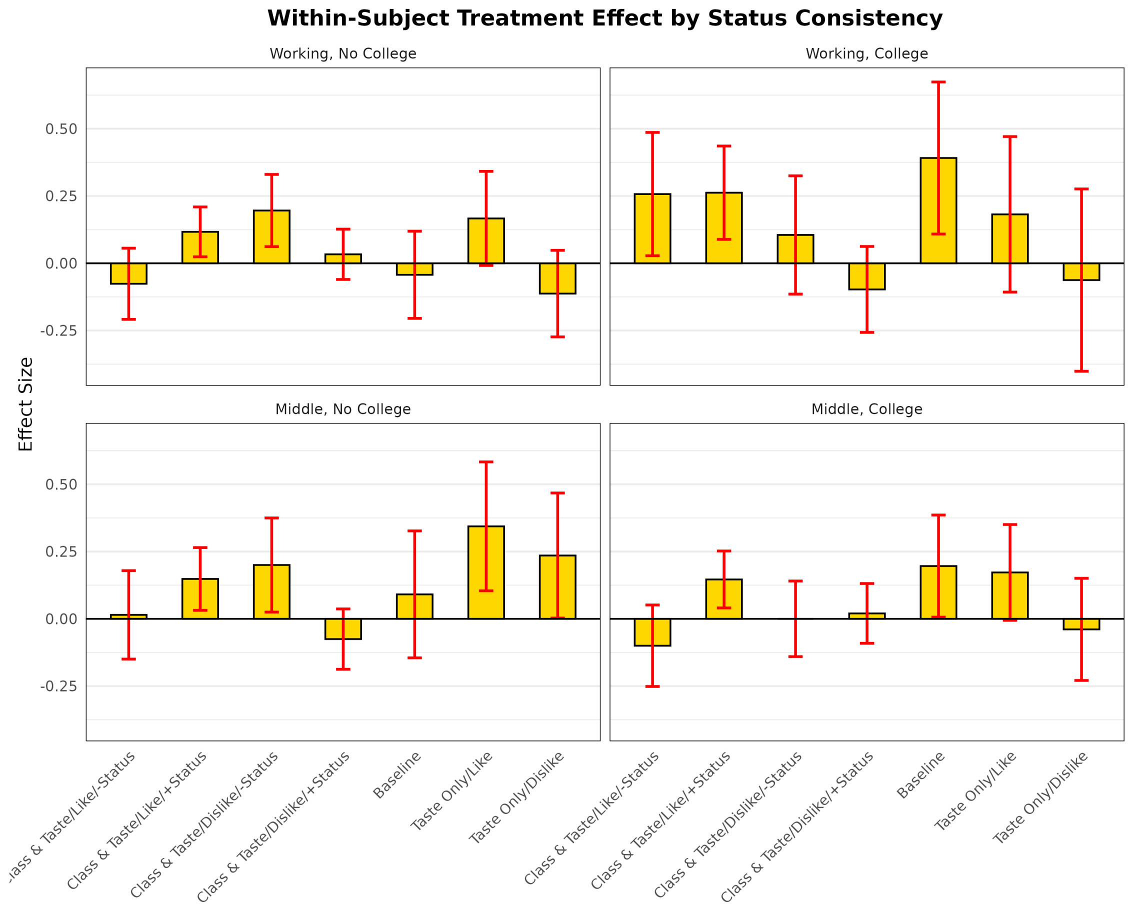

Figure 1: Within-Subject Treatment Effect by Status Consistency

3.4 Disaggregating Behavior: Conformity vs. Reactance

Because a linear shift obscures whether a respondent is moving *toward* (Conformity) or *away from* (Reactance) the group, we map the behavioral shifts and fit a Multinomial Logistic Regression model.

This reveals that Middle Class individuals without a college degree are highly prone to *conformity*, whereas Working Class individuals with a college degree display the highest baseline probability of *reactance*.

3.5 Robustness: Covariate Balancing via IPW

To ensure these class-based findings are not driven by confounding demographics (like age or race disparities between education groups), we apply Propensity Score Weighting.

Even after weighting, the structural differences in behavior across status groups remain remarkably consistent (see Figure 4).

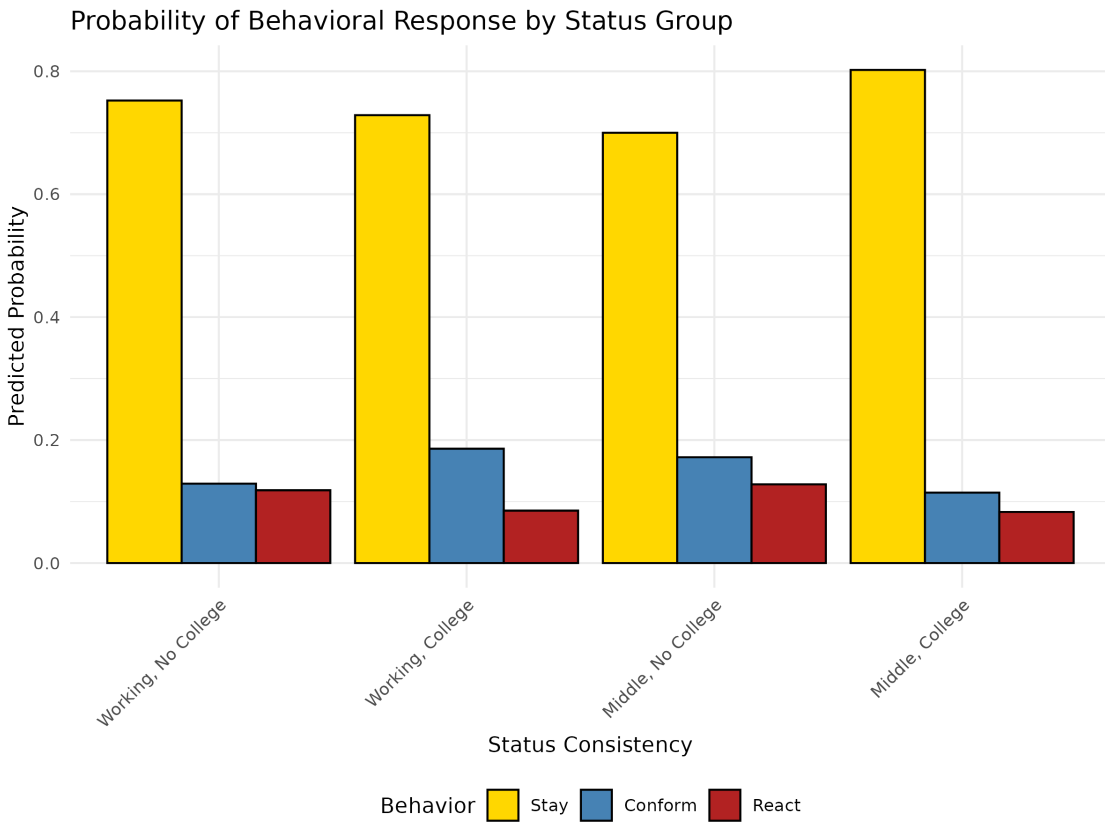

Figure 2: Probability of Behavioral Response by Status Group

3.6 Sensitivity Analysis: Isolating Class Feedback

To ensure that the results are driven by the *class status* of the fictional alter groups, we run a sensitivity analysis dropping the "Taste Only" conditions.

The probability distributions of conformity versus reactance remain highly consistent with the main findings, confirming that the presence of class-based status information uniquely structures the evaluation shifts of respondents.

4 Discussion and Conclusion

Our analysis demonstrates that aesthetic judgments are deeply malleable, but not uniformly so. The findings advance the sociology of culture in several ways:

1. **Directionality Matters:** By replacing a binary "stay/shift" conceptualization with a multinomial "stay/conform/react" framework, we reveal that cultural influence involves both emulation and boundary-drawing.

2. **Status Inconsistency as a Driver of Change:** Respondents with inconsistent status markers (e.g., Working class with a college degree, or Middle class without) are the most aesthetically fluid. However, they resolve this fluidity differently, leaning heavily into reactance or conformity depending on their exact social location.

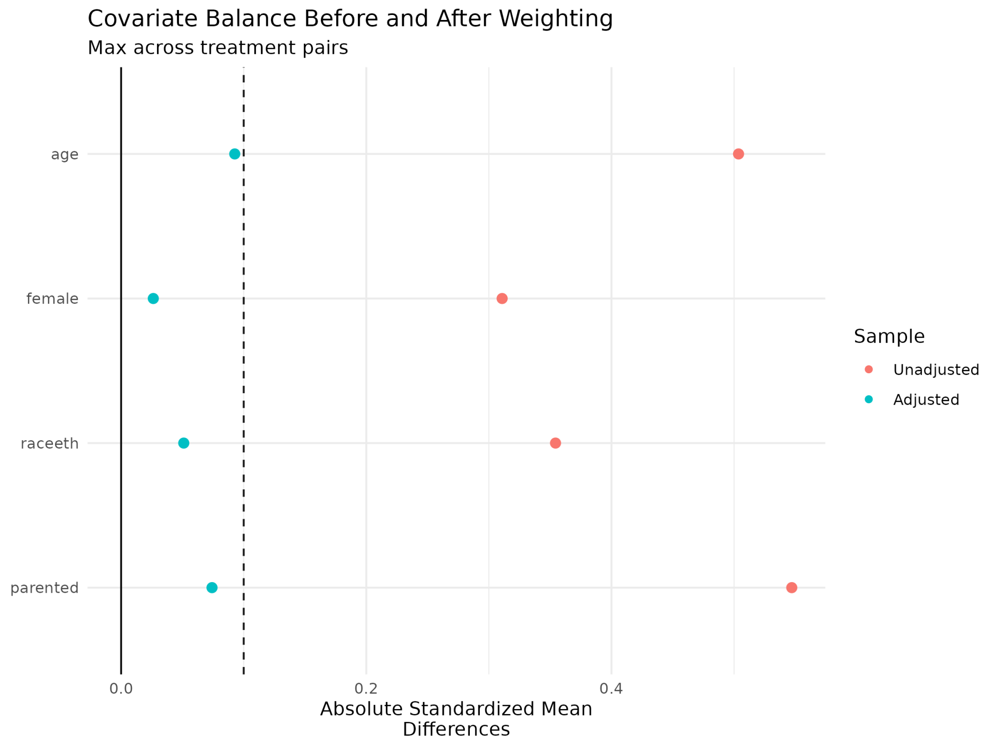

Figure 3: Covariate Balance Before and After Weighting

3. **Methodological Rigor:** By employing Cumulative Link Mixed Models and Propensity Score Weighting, we establish that these dynamics are neither statistical artifacts of ordinal scales nor observational confounding.

Taste is indeed a social product, shaped continuously by class consciousness, educational capital, and the omnipresent evaluation of our peers.

References

Berger, J. and Heath, C. (2008). Who drives divergence? identity signaling, outgroup dissimilarity, and the abandonment of cultural tastes. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 95(3):593–607.

Bourdieu, P. (1984). *Distinction: A social critique of the judgement of taste*. Harvard university press.

Bryson, B. (1996). "anything but heavy metal": Symbolic exclusion and musical dislikes. *American Sociological Review*, 61(5):884–899.

DiMaggio, P. (1987). Classification in art. *American Sociological Review*, pages 440–455.

Erickson, B. H. (1996). Culture, class, and connections. *American Journal of Sociology*, 102(1):217–251.

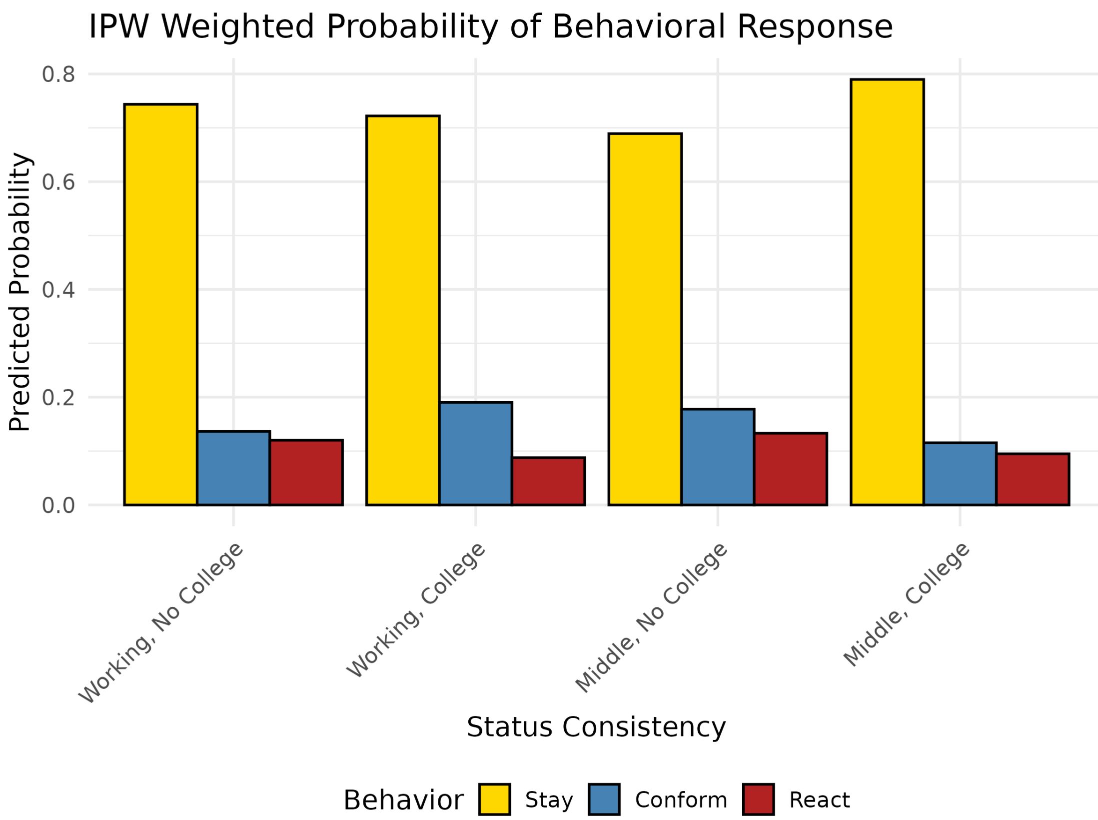

Figure 4: IPW Weighted Probability of Behavioral Response

Lamont, M. and Molnár, V. (2002). The study of boundaries in the social sciences. *Annual review of sociology*, 28(1):167–195.

Lizardo, O. (2006). How cultural tastes shape personal networks. *American Sociological Review*, 71(5):778–807.

Simmel, G. (1957). Fashion. *American journal of sociology*, 62(6):541–558.

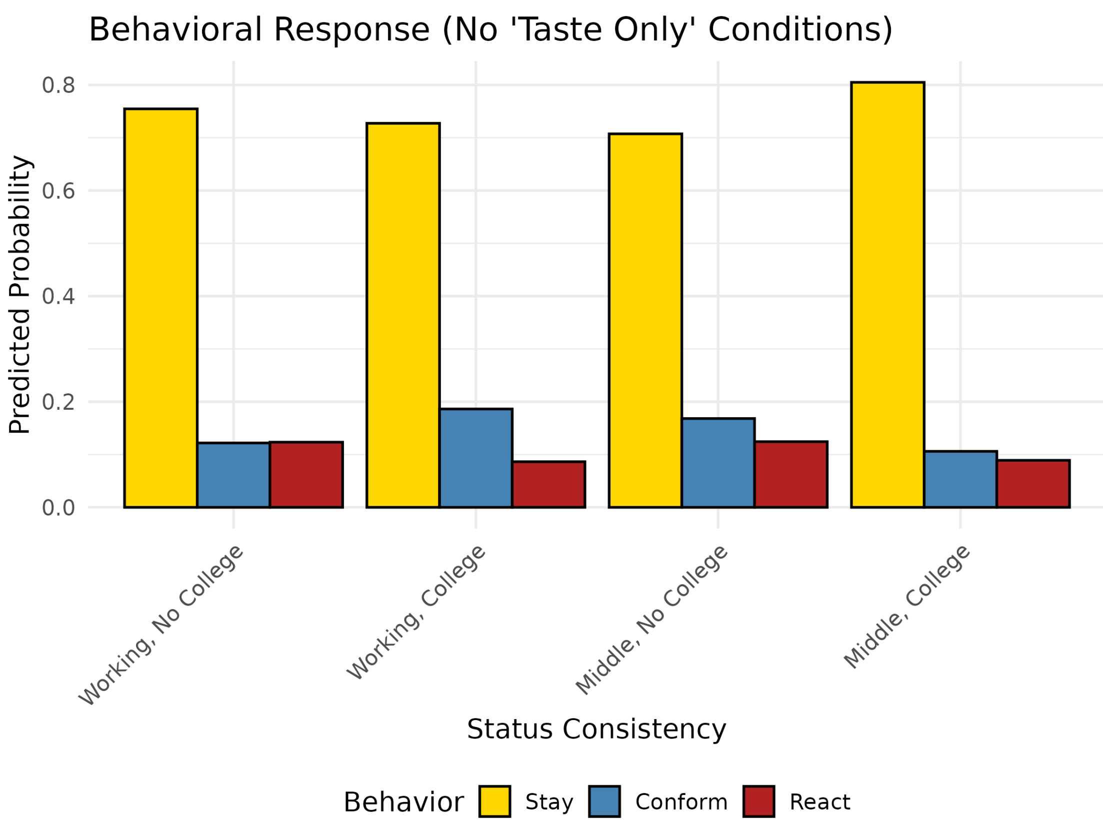

Figure 5: Behavioral Response (Excluding 'Taste Only' Conditions)